of the mother during lactation mainly depends on the volume of milk produced, duration of lactation, and the composition of breastmilk to meet the requirements of the growing infant.

2.2.1 Role of hormones in milk production

Sucking by infant initiates hormonal changes that leads to milk production and let down reflex, which releases milk as shown in figure 2.4

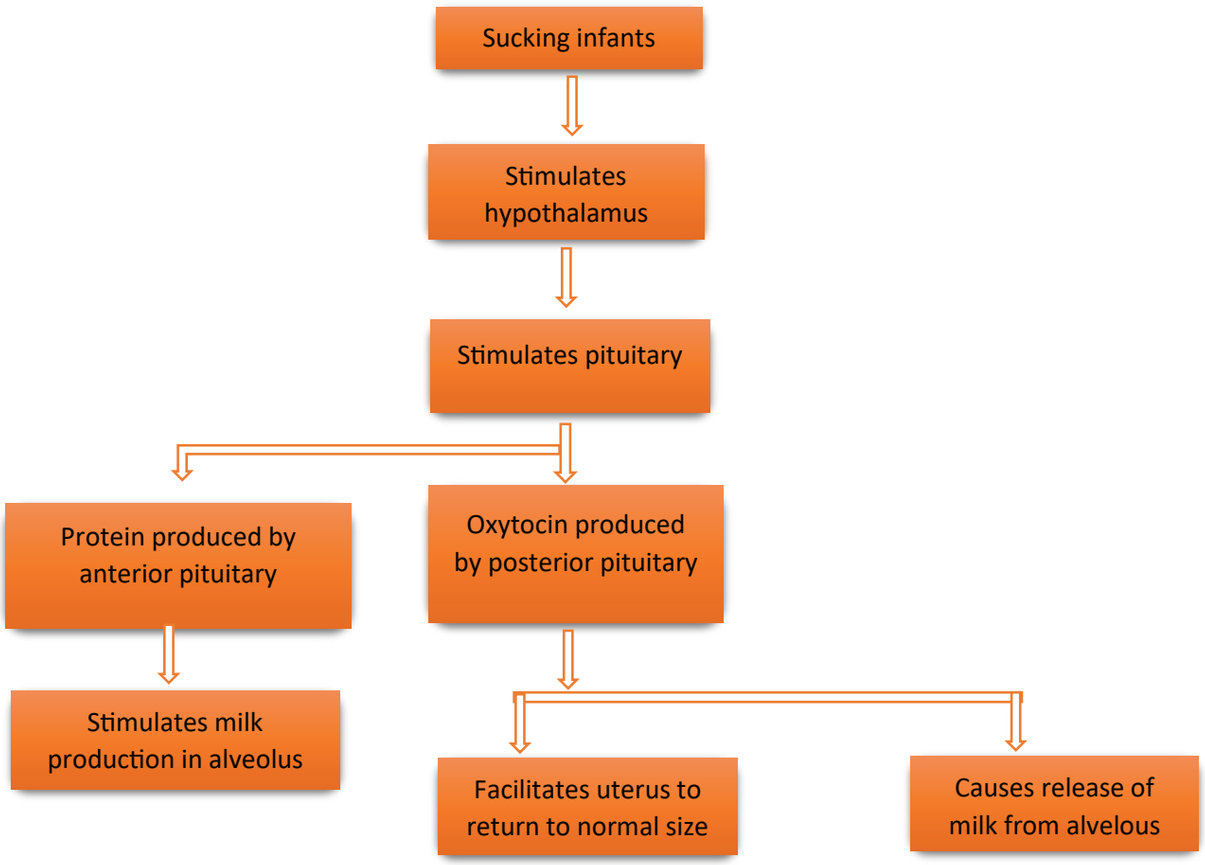


Fig 2.4 process of stimulation of milk production

This process of lactation is controlled by various hormones. The source of the hormones and their function is summarised in table 2.4

Table 2.4 Hormonal control of lactation

HORMONE	SOURCE	ACTIVITY
Oestrogen	Ovary and placenta	Stimulates breast development during pregnancy
Progesterone	Ovary and placenta	Stimulates breast development during pregnancy
Prolactin	Anterior pituitary gland	Simulates milk production
Oxytocin	Posterior pituitary gland	"Let down" reflex: Smooth muscles surrounding the alveoli of the nipples contract to allow the release of milk.

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